DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

How Do You Love and Fear God?

Derech Hashem 4:3:1-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 3, paragraphs 1-3 (the chapter on love and fear of God) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 27 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A continuation

This recording continues the previous one from the same evening. Having finished the chapter on Torah study, the Rabbi turned to Part 4, chapter 3: the love and fear of God, the first of the constant misvot.

Paragraph 1: true love and true fear

The Ramhal recalls that in Part 1 he explained briefly that love and fear are what bring a person close to God and make him cleave to Him. He means true love and true fear: love of God Himself, not love of reward; fear of His exaltedness, not fear of punishment.

So what does it mean to love God? "How do you love something you've never seen?" A participant suggested feeling in harmony, and copying His characteristics, which is how one cleaves to Him.

The Rabbi brought the Rambam. How does one come to love and fear God? When a person contemplates God's creations and sees in them wisdom without end, he immediately loves, praises and longs to know God. Look at the fish, the creatures, the insects, the fruit, the science of the world. Studying nature brings love of God.

This is why, as learned with the Thirteen Principles, a true prophet must have an immaculate understanding of science. "You can't be deficient in science without that being a deficiency in your love of HaKadosh Barukh Hu." Loving God because you want Olam HaBa, or more reward for each misvah, is not love of God. "That's love of reward. That's love of yourself, really." Real love is standing among the mountains and saying "wow".

Nature and the city

A participant raised the damage to the environment. The Rabbi: that is the work of human beings, a lack of care on our part, not a flaw in creation. Another said that living in a city deadens this sense; even Tashlikh beside what is practically a sewer loses its meaning. The Rabbi agreed that being cooped up in cities with cars and roads is not the natural state in

which we are meant to live, and that it is important to spend time in nature. "You look at a skyscraper, you love human beings." A waterfall shows you God.

Fear as awe

What is fear of God? Not fear of punishment or of hell, but awe at His exaltedness. The Rambam continues that when you truly love God and understand His world, you immediately come to fear Him. In fact, for the Rambam, fear is a higher level than love.

The Rabbi's analogy: you have been lucky enough to meet a very special person, who has given you their number, and you are in love. Now you worry: will I write correctly, will I speak to them properly? "That's fear." Fear born of love, the fear of making a mistake. "It's a fear of opportunity. I don't want to waste this opportunity to have this relationship."

He distinguished this from a different kind of fear: anxious precision in misvot, measuring exactly how many grams one must eat. That is not awe at God's greatness. In that respect, love is better than anxious fear. But true awe is "the fear of wow".

Paragraph 2: the Shekhinah rests on such a person

One who reaches this fear has the Shekhinah resting on him constantly. We find this with Moshe. The pasuk says, "What does God ask of you? Only to fear." Only? Hazal answer that for Moshe it was easy. For ordinary people it is very hard to live in that state. The more one attains, the greater one's purity and holiness, especially in study and in misvot. Awe contributes to the perfection of every misvah and of Torah study.

Paragraph 3: love, belief and trust

Love is what joins a person to God and brings him great crowns. Its essence is joy, the soul burning before the Kadosh Barukh Hu, and readiness to give up one's life to do His will. "If you love your spouse, you will do anything for them."

Part of love and fear is belief in God and especially trust in Him. All these strengthen each other: when you love and fear God, you come to trust Him better and have a better relationship. These are constant misvot, which can be done at any moment of the day.

Noam Elimelekh: a misvah for sleepless nights

The Rabbi closed with the will of the Hasidic master Rabbi Elimelekh of Lizhensk, the Noam Elimelekh, whose grave many visit each year. When you cannot study or do anything else, for instance when you are lying in bed unable to sleep, picture a huge fire rising to the heart of heaven, with those around you demanding that you convert or jump in, and see yourself jumping into the fire. That is the misvah of Kiddush Hashem and of love of God, always available. "If you can't do it, at least think about it." And with that, you will fall asleep.

Summary

- True love of God is love of God Himself, not of reward; true fear is awe, not fear of punishment.

- Love comes from studying the wisdom of God's world, which is why science matters.
- For the Rambam, awe flows from love and stands higher than it: the fear of spoiling a precious relationship.
- One who lives with this awe has the Shekhinah resting on him, like Moshe.
- Love includes readiness to give one's life, and it is joined to belief and trust in God.

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